MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 3: Poetry - Dutt, Tagore, Kolatkar, Patel and Kalia

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH • M21EG04DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

These poems make trees, offerings, encounters, and domestic experience into questions about memory, devotion, poverty, ecological violence, and gender.

Start with a picture

A tree can hold memories, a tiny gift can transform a beggar’s understanding, and a brief encounter can unsettle a visitor’s confidence. Poetry gives ordinary objects a structure of thought.

1. Toru Dutt: Our Casuarina Tree

The tree’s physical life leads into memories of absent companions and emotional continuity across distance. Natural description is not an alternative to grief; it becomes a medium through which attachment survives.

The later wish to preserve the tree through poetry connects natural endurance with literary remembrance. Explain the movement from observation to memory and the act of commemoration.

2. Tagore: Gitanjali, Songs 1, 6, 50, and 103

Song 1: the speaker’s finite life is repeatedly renewed through a relationship with the divine. The vessel and musical instrument images express dependence and creative possibility.

Song 6: a flower’s possible fading gives urgency to an offering. The speaker asks to be accepted before the opportunity disappears. Fragility becomes part of devotion rather than a reason to postpone it.

Song 50: a beggar expects a gift from a royal figure but is asked to give. A small grain returned as gold makes the failure to give more a painful discovery. The reversal questions calculation and generosity.

Song 103: senses, songs, and the self move towards a final act of salutation and surrender. Images join multiplicity with an encompassing orientation towards the divine.

These are dramatic devotional situations. Do not reduce all four to the statement “God is great”; explain their different images and movements.

3. Arun Kolatkar: An Old Woman

A woman’s request for work or payment meets the visitor’s wish to disengage. The encounter changes the scale of perception, making an apparently small, dismissed figure disrupt the observer’s secure position.

The poem questions a tourist gaze that treats landscape or pilgrimage as an experience detached from poverty. Preserve the woman’s agency; she is not merely an object placed there to educate a comfortable visitor.

4. Gieve Patel: On Killing a Tree

The procedural language explains that cutting alone may not destroy a tree: roots and their relation to earth matter. Its attention to the effort of killing exposes both the tree’s resilience and deliberate human violence.

The instructional tone is ironic, not a practical endorsement of ecological destruction. Analyse the verbs, bodily associations, and sequence through which life is dismantled.

5. Mamta Kalia: After Eight Years of Marriage

A married woman’s return to her parents makes the question of happiness difficult to answer. Domestic work, expectations, and concealed distress complicate the appearance of normal family life.

A smile or a nod can hide rather than settle experience. Tone and the gap between outward response and inward feeling expose the cost of prescribed female roles.

Quick check

1. What reverses the beggar’s expectation in Song 50? **He is asked to give.**
2. Does Patel straightforwardly celebrate killing? **No; the procedural voice creates irony.**
3. Is Kalia’s outward smile proof of happiness? **No.**

Build an exam answer

1. Explain concrete image as a structure of thought.
2. Analyse Dutt’s movement from nature to memory.
3. Distinguish the four Tagore songs.
4. Use irony or perspective in a modern poem.
5. Compare how familiar values are revised.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not merge the four Gitanjali songs into one summary or mistake an ironic voice for straightforward instruction.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Discuss how concrete images challenge habitual ways of valuing people, nature, and devotion.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The selected poems turn ordinary images into occasions for reconsidering value. Dutt's tree is both a living presence and a focus of memory. Its significance grows through the relation between a particular landscape and absent companions, so the final commemorative impulse is more than a general admiration of nature.

Tagore's devotional situations likewise depend on specific forms of exchange and offering. The grain in Song 50 exposes the limits of the beggar's calculation, while the fragile flower in Song 6 makes delay a spiritual problem. A comparison should preserve these different structures instead of dissolving them into a single theme of faith.

Kolatkar, Patel, and Kalia redirect attention towards what conventional perception may minimise. The old woman unsettles the visitor's scale of importance; the tree's roots make killing a sustained act of violence; the wife's limited outward response reveals how domestic suffering can remain unacknowledged. The poems' ethical force emerges through language and perspective rather than an added moral slogan.

A good answer selects a few images and explains their movement within the poem. Nature, spirituality, and society are connected through acts of seeing, giving, remembering, and refusing to notice. The reader's own assumptions about importance become part of what the poems examine.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt's assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Analyse symbolic meaning in "Our Casuarina Tree."
2. Examine spiritual themes in selected songs from Gitanjali.
3. Compare romantic and modernist techniques in Tagore and Kolatkar.
4. Discuss environmental imagery and irony in "On Killing a Tree."
5. Interpret social commentary in "After Eight Years of Marriage."